

Windows Gives Cloud Cover to Linux

After launching an open source subsidiary, Microsoft has taken another step towards openness. In its latest move, Microsoft is offering Linux-based operating systems on its Azure cloud service. The company's Azure portal comes with a variety of Linux distributions, which include SUSE Linux Enterprise Server 11 SP2, OpenSUSE 12.01, CentOS 6.2 and Canonical Ubuntu 12.04. Users are free to select and install any of these distros from the Microsoft Windows Azure Image Gallery.

Let's have a look at what Microsoft is offering. Bill Laing, corporate VP, Server and Cloud, made the announcement by saying...

"Hybrid cloud, which involves the use and building of applications that connect to data and services across a mix of data centers, is the reality for cloud computing today. Businesses and applications will move to the cloud in their own unique way, at their own unique speed. Supporting this change requires a cloud solution that provides the necessary flexibility for the different ways you will architect, develop and deploy your applications and IT solutions—be it on-premises, in the cloud, or a mix of both."

The new Windows Azure services simplify building applications that span cloud and on-premises servers. By combining infrastructure and platform services, these new capabilities of Windows Azure give greater flexibility in how to build or bring applications to the cloud. Some of the highlights of the new enhancements include:

- **Windows Azure virtual machines (VMs):** VMs give you application mobility, allowing you to move your virtual hard disks (VHDs) back and forth between on-premises and the cloud. Users can migrate existing workloads such as Microsoft SQL Server or Microsoft SharePoint to the cloud, bring their own customised Windows Server or Linux images, or select from a gallery. As a common virtualisation file format, VHD has been adopted by hundreds of vendors and is a freely available specification covered under the Microsoft Open Specification Promise.



Mandar Naik, director, Platform Strategy,
Microsoft India

- **Windows Azure virtual network:** This lets you provision and manage virtual private networks (VPNs) in Windows Azure as well as securely extend on-premises networks into the cloud. It provides control over network topology, including configuration of IP addresses, routing tables and security policies, and uses the industry-standard IPSEC protocol to provide a secure connection between your corporate VPN gateway and Windows Azure.
 - **Windows Azure websites:** You can build websites and applications with this highly elastic solution supporting .NET, Node.js and PHP, while using common deployment techniques like Git and FTP. Windows Azure websites will also allow easy deployment to the cloud of open source applications like WordPress, Joomla!, DotNetNuke, Umbraco and Drupal—with just a few clicks.
 - **New tools, language support, and SDK:** The Windows Azure SDK June 2012 includes new developer capabilities for writing code against the latest service improvements, with updated support for Java, PHP and .NET, and the addition of Python as a supported language on Windows Azure. Additionally, the SDK now provides 100 per cent command line support for both Windows and the Mac OS.
- With this initiative, Microsoft, which was earlier considered a threat to open source, has demonstrated that it is now warming up to Linux. By involving developers in Azure, Microsoft sees an inevitable opportunity. Mandar Naik, director, Platform Strategy, Microsoft, said, "In the cloud, openness is paramount. We are committed to taking